see on ground," he tells us. "A kho kho match is like the last lap of Formula1." Also working in Niyogi's favour were two facts—kho kho is easy to follow and it also just as easily elicits nostalgia. Several Indians have either watched or played the sport in school.

That was how Arun S.A., 23, a defender with Telugu Yoddhas, started out. Not only did Arun make the most of the kho kho infrastructure at the Government Vocational Higher Secondary School in Kerala's Pirappancode, he also walked in his mother's and sister's footsteps, both of whom were national-level players. "My mother has been my biggest support," he says. "She even urges me to practise during the vacations, even if that means I can't come home." Recently, Arun made his mother doubly proud when his performances on the court landed him a job with Kerala's postal department. If Niyogi is to be believed, neither Ultimate Kho Kho nor the athletic talent on display is a flash in the pan. He says the league has legs to last another 20 years: "For any sport to sustain itself and develop, a professional league plays a very important role. That is applicable the world over." He says he is also looking to start a women's edition, having already had two companies reach out to purchase teams. Unlike cricket, where the women's league hasn't gained traction due to dearth of players as per the BCCI, Niyogi says women's kho kho will be at par with the men's. The confidence in this claim cannot be discounted. Ultimate Kho Kho is only proving the strength of Niyogi's convictions. ■

– Suhani Singh

INTERVIEW

ON THE FRONT FOOT

Undaunted by the weight of captaincy, cricketer **HARMANPREET KAUR**, *33, is ensuring that she and her teammates move together from strength to strength*

"To be called **HARMANPREET THOR** is very encouraging. With more responsibility, I feel more mature and selfless"



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Q. Women's cricket was included for the first time at the Commonwealth Games this year. How important was this step for the game?

We feel fortunate to have represented our nation in a multi-sport event. We challenged ourselves game after game to win a medal. During the 15 days that we stayed at the Games Village, we met all kinds of athletes and learnt about their journey, which helped us broaden our mindsets. It's a great move to include women's cricket at the Commonwealth Games.

Q. This, though, is the third time India has lost the final of a major tournament in the last five years. What needs to change to win these big matches?

Self-belief, commitment and a winning habit. We, as a team, need to create a winning environment and not get overconfident about our skills and achievements. It is important that each player carries some responsibility and wins big matches. I'm very proud of the team that we are building, yet somewhere I feel that the finishing needs to be smoother.

Q. The camaraderie between the players is evident. What are the important changes that have taken place in the dressing room?

The dressing room is more like a hang-out place for us. We enjoy, laugh, sing and dance there. We have discussions a day prior to the game in order to keep the dressing room environment light. Each player has her own space to think, plan, prepare and execute.

Q. You've played in leagues in Australia and England. How has this helped you as a player and how do you see the women's IPL helping the game?

Playing among the finest players in the world does develop a better understanding of the game. I'm sure the women's IPL will bring a lot to the table for big talents to display their game in various capacities.

Q. You've earned the nickname "Harmanpreet Thor" for your hard-hitting...

There was a fan who would bring a poster to the match every time with my name as "HarmanPreet THOR". After that, my team started addressing me the same way. This Marvel character is known for its power and energy and to be called that is very encouraging.

Q. You made your India debut in 2009. How have you changed as a cricketer?

I was always an aggressive cricketer who wanted results. But with more responsibilities coming my way, I realise that I am getting mature and selfless. ■

–with Shail Desai